Wigfield

By Amy Sedaris, Paul Direlio and Stephen Colbert

RUSSELL HOKES: Welcome to Wigfield. Population: vague. Driven by the government's recent threat to destroy the local dam, and with it the self-described "town" of Wigfield, residents must race against the clock. The real question: Is Wigfield merely posing as a town in order to collect federal disaster relief?

INTRODUCTION

Today you'll hear personal accounts from the chief of police, 3 self-declared mayors; and an elected government official who will provide a snapshot of "small town"America – which I'm sure you will come to realize is more than "just a little ditty 'bout Jack and Diane." Wigfield by Amy Sedaris, Paul Direlio and Stephen Colbert.

RUSSELL HOKES: Wigfield is a quarter-mile stretch of highway known as Wigfield. As is the case with many small towns, Wigfield is totally isolated, with the exception of the four-lane interstate that runs parallel to its Main (and only) Street.

I walked down the road staring into the shops, searching for something in this town to tell me its story. I read the signs hanging in the storefront windows: DAM BEING TORN DOWN SALE! EVERYTHING MUST GO BEFORE THE DAM IS TORN DOWN AND TOWN IS DESTROYED!

Wigfield is endangered! I decide to let the town residents tell their story in their own words . . . . I set forth to meet the People of Wigfield.

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HOYT GEIN: I'm Hoyt Gein, the police chief under Charles Halstead, who is the legitimately self-declared may or Wigfield. I know some townspeople have criticized Mayor Halstead for appointing me chief of police, given my arson arrest record, but come on now, that's just ludicrous. I can stop lighting fires anytime I want. Yes, I occasionally start fires when I'm out at a social event, but so what? Who doesn't? It's a free country.

Fleet Hollinger thought he could force me out . . . he'll hold an election, and just because he's the most powerful man in town, he'll get elected. Well, that not the way things work. A curious electrical fire at the polling station saw to that. It turns out it's pretty hard to exercise your right to vote when you're on fire. Case closed. In the confusion, the town ended up with three mayors.

Maybe saving a little town like Wigfield isn't important to most people, but it's important to me. I know most people don't cotton to small towns,. Like lemmings, they follow everyone else to the cities, where they can find jobs, housing, and culture. But in Wigfield we march to is the beat of our hearts. You scrape away the unemployment, the unsolved murders, or even the contaminated topsoil, and what you'll find is the giant swollen heart of America.

RUSSELL HOKES: And then Hoyt demanded that I follow him out to his camper van. Any doubt I had as to his official capacity was dispelled by the words "Wigfield's Police Chief" stenciled on the side. Throwing open the rear cargo door with a flourish, he proudly displayed a man win his early forties who was elaborately seat-belted into a lawn chair. According to Hoyt, this cheerfully disheveled man was Mayor Charles Halstead, who had insisted on meeting me.

CHARLES HALSTEAD: I like fudge. I have a briefcase. I keep my fudge in there. I'm not from here, but I live here now. I came to this town to represent the lead

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dispersal plant. The government wanted to close it because they said it was retarding the employees. I got a court order that allowed me to stay at the plant so I could disprove firsthand the effects of the plant. After I lost the case, I decided to stay in Wigfield. I don't know why. I like fudge. Guess what I have in my briefcase. I'm one of the mayors. I hope they don't tear down the dam. My fudge would get wet.

RUSSELL HOKES: I knew now that a vital part of this story was the mayor. All three of him. I had met one, but I knew that some more of them were out there. My search quickly led me to the business establishment of Mayor Burchal Sawyer. We met in his vast junkyard.

BURCHAL SAWYER: I'm the great American success story. One day you're livin' out of your car, the next you're livin' out of your car, and you're the mayor of a town. That's because I make things happen.

Listen to this. Fleet Hollinger tried to tell me that I couldn't run for mayor of this town because I didn't have a residence. I was livin' in my car at the time. Then he gets his [shorts] all in a bunch just 'cause I didn't have any identification. I know who I am. I don't need fingerprints to prove it. Plus, he says that I'm not educated, and that's a crock. Look, last time I checked this was a free country.

Speaking of which, as one of the mayors, I feel I should chime in about this dam business. On the record, my official reaction is this: Why would the state want to tear our dam down? It just doesn't make any sense: flooding a river bed? What kind of logic is that? You think just because I'm used to livin' in my car it will be easy for me to pull up stakes and drive to another place? But again, if it's got to come down, well then, I say, as a community we prepare ourselves for

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the horrifying loss we must endure, and on behalf of the town I accept my relocation money graciously.

RUSSELL HOKES: This only left Fleet Hollinger to complete the trifecta of local leadership. Logic said his home. A series of double and singlewide trailers had been hauled into an impressive maze of aluminum and connected in a haphazard fashion with sheet metal and button rivets. Clearly this was the home of an important man.

FLEET HOLLINGER: I'm a simple man in a simple town. Small towns are built on old-time values. Friendliness, openness, trust. That's what I'm all about. Besides the used car lot, I also own Fleet's Used Auto Parts – the oldest business in Wigfield. Another business I run is Mack (M-A-C-K) Donalds. The only and the best fast-food chain in Wigfield. As we speak, a large hamburger chain is trying to shut me down. All I know is my middle name is Donald and my nickname is Mack because this guy I know dries a truck. It seemed natural to me that a clown would be the mascot. How can they have a lock on that? When you think of hamburgers, you think of cows, cows make you think of bullfights, and who distracts the bulls? Clowns! I named the clown after my nephew Ronald. I wouldn't be surprised if that unnamed hamburger chain is involved in this whole dam thing.

Along with being a respected businessman, I'm also the mayor. Now, I'm sure the government sees us as a bunch of squatters who gradually accumulated at the bottom of a newly dry riverbed. But we will battle tirelessly to keep our town, and nothing will deter us!

RUSSELL HOKES: Through my many interviews with the mayors of Wigfield a story was starting to shape up. But my journalistic sense of fair play told me that

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Representative Bill Farber deserved the chance to give his side of the story. I decided to track him down.

FARBER: First of all, Wigfield isn't a town. These people are living here illegally. Half of those people don't have social security numbers. They don't even have a zip code. They don't pay any taxes. They're outside of any health care system or school district. But even though they have built illegally on land that belongs to the state, we are willing to discuss a nominal relocation fee. The state will not recognize this place as a town.

RUSSELL HOKES: Well, I guess that will all be settled today in court.

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JUDGE: Be seated. We have a motion filed by the town of Wigfield. At this time the plaintiffs can make their opening statement.

FLEET: You Honor, or scenic little town is nestled quaintly in the shadow of the Bulkwaller Dam. Our tiny little hamlet will soon be washed away by the cold, unforgiving waters of the so-called Fresh Springs River. I call Eminent Domain! If residents are relocated by the state, they must be financially compensated for both home and property. The pain is immeasurable, as should be our compensation.

FARBER: Your Honor, eminent domain only applies to legally occupied incorporated towns. There is no precedent for payment to what really amounts t o illegal squatters, no matter how many mayors they claim to have.

FLEET: How dare you?! Are you suggesting that we are merely posing as a town in order to get money when the dam is torn down?

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RUSSELL HOKES: Your Honor, my name is Russell Hokes. I am a writer. Now perhaps these people don't possess the necessary legal documents stating they are a town. But I'll tell you this much, Judge. I have lived with these people for nearly two weeks now. I've seen their children play on the mercury mound. I think I can say with great confidence that if Wigfield is not a town, then I am not a writer.

JUDGE COLEMAN: I'm going to take this matter under consideration. The demolition of Bulkwaller Dam is stayed for one month. You will have that one month to prove you are a town. If you can't prove your township, the dam may come down and the state will have no financial obligation to you whatsoever.

RUSSELL HOKES: At first the town struggled for a solution: 1) Add the words "Town of" to the Wigfield sign. 2) Get a Wigfield sign and 3) Parade!

What better way to prove you are something you are not than to celebrate the very thing that someone says you aren't! And what better way to celebrate than with a parade?

What happened next is almost impossible to believe. A reporter at one of the big-city papers wrote a human-interest story about the travails of Wigfield. "Small Town Parades to Save Self." Anyway, somehow that story piqued the interest of other newspapers. Soon, they began showing up in Wigfield. Stories began to spread, and before long crowds began to show up along the parade route.

Representative Farber has informed the town that he would like to address them.

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FARBER: Well, ladies and gentlemen, what I have to say is very simple. You win. The state is bowing to public pressure and has decided not to tear down the Bulkwaller Dam.

RUSSELL HOKES: A chant of "where's our money" rings out from the floor and begins to build

FARBER: I don't have any money for you, but I do have your new town charter. You should know that among the responsibilities that come with townhood are providing proper sewage, streetlights, a school system . . . well, the list goes on. A tax will have to be levied on the citizens and businesses to pay for all that, of course. You have until the first of the year to initiate these actions.

FLEET: What if we don't?

FARBER: The town will be dissolved, your property confiscated without compensation, you will be forcibly removed from the area and all town officials, which I might remind you are legally listed as Hollinger, Sawyer, Gein and Halstead will be subject o criminal prosecution. Good day, gentlemen.

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RUSSELL HOKES: Hello, Mr. and Mrs. America, this is Russell Hokes coming to you live from the first annual Wigfield Town Charter Celebration. It's just about dusk, and I suspect people will begin gearing up for the fireworks display. Hoyt Gein is moving toward the base of the dam carrying fuses, a torch, and other explosive delights. I can only imagine what flaming wonders will emerge from the deep shafts bored directly into the face of the dam.

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It's exploding! It's exploding! The whole dam is exploding! Oh, the humanity! I can't talk! I can't breathe! The dam is a mass of smoking rubble. Water is crashing through the smoking wreckage! The entire town is being submerged!

(5 days later)

Who lived? They all did. In the time that it takes most people to change into their grieving black, the people of Wigfield have bounced back as if their souls were made out of Superballs. The mind reels at the fact that given a disaster of this proportion, almost every member of the town survived, and not only that, they were able to miraculously salvage nearly every possession. God has smiled on these people. Amid all this mournful merriment, one agonizing question remains. What now?

FLEET: Well, here's the deal. I've talked to the boys down at the Federal Emergency Management Agency, and apparently we qualify for disaster relief. The only thing we need in order to get what is justifiably coming to us is this little written account of the tragedy by an impartial third-party witness . .

RUSSELL HOKES: Then is struck me. Third-party account? Why I could be that account! . . . . . [So I leave you with this question]: Was Wigfield merely posing as a town in order to collect federal disaster relief? [The world may never know].

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
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